

— THE — **CYBER CATALYST™** — METHOD —

ZERO-TO-JOB ROADMAP



A COMPLETE BLUEPRINT FOR BEGINNERS TO
LAUNCH A CYBERSECURITY CAREER

VICTORIA SIMON OMAOJO
— THE CYBER CATALYST —

THE ZERO-TO-JOB CYBERSECURITY CLARITY SYSTEM

A Structured Execution Blueprint for Beginners Who Want to Become Employable

INTRODUCTION

Why This Book Exists

Most beginners fail in cybersecurity for one simple reason: they try to learn everything at once.

They watch endless tutorials, collect certifications, follow different influencers, jump between red team and blue team, and after months, sometimes years, they still cannot confidently say, “I am job ready.”

This book exists to eliminate chaos.

It is not a motivational book.

It is not a list of random resources.

It is not a theoretical overview.

It is a structured execution system.

By the end of this book, you will:

- Choose one clear path
- Understand exactly what to study
- Build a portfolio that proves skill
- Develop visibility strategically
- Apply for jobs with confidence and evidence

This is about transformation from confusion to competence.



PART 1: UNDERSTANDING THE INDUSTRY WITHOUT DROWNING

Cybersecurity is broad because it protects systems, data, infrastructure, people, and businesses. But the job market does not hire “broad.” It hires specific roles.

Your first task is not to learn tools.

Your first task is to understand positioning.

One of the most damaging myths beginners believe is that cybersecurity is one role.

It is not.

Cybersecurity is an interconnected ecosystem of technical, strategic, investigative, operational, and compliance-based roles.

Understanding this early prevents unrealistic expectations.

There are two major entry routes into the ecosystem:

1. Direct Security Entry
2. Strategic Technical Entry

Both are valid. Both lead to growth. Both require discipline.

DIRECT ENTRY ROLES

These roles place you directly within a security team.

1. Security Operations Center (SOC) Analyst

A SOC analyst monitors alerts, investigates suspicious activity, analyzes logs, and escalates confirmed threats.

Daily responsibilities may include:

- Reviewing SIEM alerts

Investigating unusual login behavior

Identifying brute-force attempts

Analyzing network traffic

Documenting incidents

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This role strengthens:

- Log analysis skills
- Pattern recognition
- Incident triage methodology
- Defensive security thinking

SOC is often considered the most accessible direct entry security role.

It rewards consistency, curiosity, and analytical precision.

2. Digital Forensics and Incident Response (DFIR)

DFIR professionals investigate breaches after they occur.

They:

- Analyze compromised systems
- Extract forensic artifacts
- Reconstruct attack timelines
- Write detailed technical reports

This role demands patience, technical depth, and investigative thinking.

You must understand file systems, logs, memory analysis, and system behavior.

DFIR professionals are trusted because they reconstruct truth.

3. Threat Intelligence

Threat intelligence focuses on understanding adversaries.

Professionals in this field:

- Track threat actors
- Analyze campaigns
- Map techniques to frameworks
- Produce intelligence reports

This role combines technical awareness with research and analytical writing.

It is ideal for structured thinkers who enjoy connecting patterns and producing strategic insights.

STRATEGIC ENTRY ROLES (HIGHLY POWERFUL PATHWAYS)

Not every professional enters cybersecurity directly.

Many build technical leverage first.

These adjacent roles often create stronger long-term security professionals.

4. Cloud Support and Cloud Security Path

Modern organizations operate in cloud environments such as:

- Amazon Web Services
- Microsoft Azure
- Google Cloud

Cloud support roles teach:

- Identity and Access Management
 - Virtual machine configuration
 - Network segmentation
 - Storage security
 - Access policies

From cloud operations, you transition naturally into cloud security roles.

Cloud security is one of the most in-demand areas globally.

Understanding architecture before securing it makes you extremely valuable.

5. Governance, Risk and Compliance (GRC)

Not all cybersecurity roles are deeply technical.

GRC professionals focus on:

- Security policy development
- Risk assessments

- Compliance frameworks
- Audit preparation
- Control implementation

They bridge technical teams and business leadership.

This path is ideal for individuals who are analytical, structured, and strong communicators.

GRC builds authority in business-aligned security.

6. IT Help Desk

Help desk is often underestimated.

It should not be.

In help desk roles, you learn:

- Operating system troubleshooting
- Network diagnostics
- Account provisioning
- Active Directory management
- Enterprise workflows

You gain exposure to real infrastructure.

Many senior security professionals began here.

Help desk builds practical maturity.

7. Technical or System Administration

System administrators manage:

- Servers
- Patching
- User permissions
- Infrastructure configuration
- Network settings

Security teams rely heavily on system administrators.

Why?

Because security failures often originate from infrastructure misconfigurations.

Infrastructure knowledge accelerates security growth.

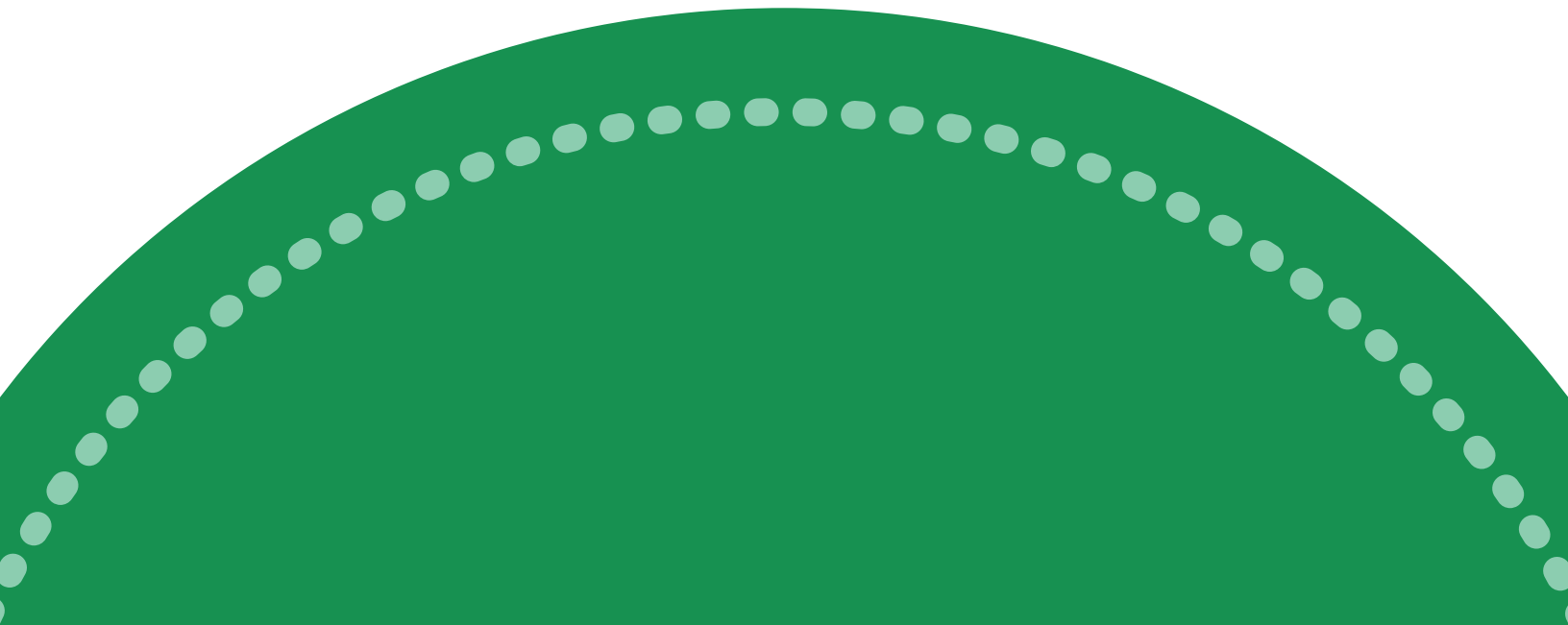
Exercise 1: Path Clarity Worksheet

Write detailed answers to these:

1. What type of problem do I enjoy solving?
2. Do I prefer real-time alert handling or deep investigation?
3. Do I enjoy research and writing?
4. Can I see myself analyzing logs daily?

Circle one path. Commit to it for six months.

No switching unless strategic.



PART 2: THE NON-NEGOTIABLE FOUNDATIONS

Before specialization, there are foundational skills you must master.

If you skip these, everything else becomes surface knowledge.

Networking Fundamentals

You must deeply understand:

- How data moves across networks
- What IP addresses represent
- How DNS resolves domains
- The difference between TCP and UDP
- What happens during a HTTP request

Without this, you cannot understand attacks.

Linux Fundamentals

You must be comfortable with:

- File systems
- Permissions
- Log locations
- Process management
- Basic shell commands

Security tools often operate in Linux environments. If you fear the terminal, you limit your growth.

Windows Fundamentals

You must understand:

- Event logs
- Registry basics
- User account control
- Active Directory basics

Many enterprise environments run on Windows. You must be able to investigate within it.

Foundation Mastery Checklist

You are ready to specialize when you can:

- Explain how a packet travels from one machine to another.
- Read a basic log and interpret what happened.
- Navigate Linux without copying commands blindly.
- Identify suspicious login attempts in Windows logs.

If you cannot confidently do these, do not rush forward.



PART 3: THE 90-DAY EXECUTION SYSTEM

This is where transformation happens. Most beginners fail because they try to specialize before they understand infrastructure. Security sits on top of systems. If you do not understand how systems function, you cannot understand how they break. The Cyber

Catalyst™ Execution System is divided into: PHASE 1 — FOUNDATION

IMMERSION (Days 1–90)

PHASE 2 — STRUCTURED SPECIALIZATION (Days 91–180)

This is not fast.

This is correct.

PHASE 1: FOUNDATION IMMERSION (Days 1–90)

Goal: Build technical maturity. Understand systems deeply. Remove fear of infrastructure. Develop investigative thinking before touching security tools.

You are not learning “cybersecurity” yet.

You are learning how technology actually works.

MONTH 1 (Days 1–30)

Networking & System Behavior Mastery This month is about understanding

communication. Not memorizing port numbers.

Understanding communication.

Core Focus:

- How data travels across networks
- What actually happens when you type a URL
- DNS resolution process
- TCP handshake
- HTTP request and response lifecycle
- Common ports and services
- Basic packet analysis

You must be able to explain:

- What happens when a user visits a website.
- How two machines establish trust.
- How traffic can be intercepted.

Hands-on Activities:

- Capture network traffic and analyze it.
- Identify different protocols in packet captures.
- Observe failed vs successful connections.
- Simulate simple network errors and troubleshoot them.

By the end of Month 1, you should:

- Read packet captures without panic.
- Understand normal vs abnormal connection behavior.
- Explain networking concepts without memorized scripts.

If you cannot teach it simply, you do not understand it yet.

Month 1 Worksheet – Deep Reflection

1. Can I explain how DNS works without looking at notes?
2. Can I describe the difference between TCP and UDP in practical terms?
3. Can I analyze a basic packet capture and identify protocols?
4. Where do I still feel confused?

Write a 2-page summary titled:

“How Data Moves Across the Internet”

If you struggle writing this, revisit the content.

MONTH 2 (Days 31–60)

Operating System & Infrastructure Depth

Security professionals must understand operating systems intimately.

This month is about behavior.

Core Focus:

Linux:

- File structure hierarchy
- Permissions and ownership
- Process management
- Log locations
- Service management

Windows:

- Event logs
- Authentication mechanisms
- User account management
- Registry basics
- Active Directory fundamentals

You are learning how systems record activity.

Security investigation begins with logs.

Hands-on Activities:

- Create and delete users.
- Modify permissions and observe system behavior.
- Analyze Windows Event Logs for login attempts.
- Locate system logs in Linux and interpret them.

By the end of Month 2:

- You should not fear the command line.
- You should understand how authentication works.
- You should know where evidence lives inside a system.

You are building investigative instincts.



Month 2 Worksheet – System Maturity Audit

1. Can I confidently navigate Linux directories?
2. Do I understand how user permissions affect security?
3. Can I analyze Windows Event Viewer entries?
4. Can I explain how authentication works in simple terms?

Write:

“What Happens Behind the Scenes When a User Logs In?”

Minimum: 1 full page explanation.

MONTH 3 (Days 61–90)

Security Fundamentals & Threat Behavior Now you

introduce security - but correctly. You do not start with

tools.

You start with concepts.

Core Focus:

- CIA Triad in real-world scenarios
- Common attack vectors (phishing, brute force, malware)
- Authentication vs authorization
- Basic cryptography concepts
- Introduction to attack lifecycle thinking
- Logging and monitoring principles

You must understand:

What is normal?

What is abnormal?

Why does abnormal behavior happen?

Hands-on Activities:

- Simulate brute-force attempts in lab.
- Identify suspicious login attempts.
- Analyze basic phishing indicators.
- Write a simple incident summary.

By the end of Month 3:

- You understand how attacks happen.
- You understand where evidence appears.
- You can explain threats clearly.

Now -and only now - are you ready to specialize.

Foundation Completion Test

Before moving to specialization, you must be able to:

- ☐ Explain network communication
- ☐ Analyze logs
- ☐ Navigate Linux and Windows
- ☐ Identify suspicious behavior
- ☐ Write a basic incident summary

If any box is unchecked, do not move forward.

Competence before confidence.





PHASE 2: STRUCTURED SPECIALIZATION (Days 91–180)

Now you build depth.

This phase turns foundational knowledge into employable skill.

MONTH 4 (Days 91–120)

Tool Introduction & Workflow Understanding

You now choose your path:

SOC

DFIR

Threat Intelligence

Cloud

GRC

Help Desk / Admin Transition

This month is about understanding workflows, not mastering tools.

You learn:

- How investigations are structured
- How documentation is written
- How escalation works
- How professionals think

You perform guided labs.

You take structured notes.

You map your actions to real-world scenarios.

1 SOC ANALYST TRACK (Blue Team Operations) Outcome After 90 Days:

You can:

- Investigate alerts confidently
 - Analyze logs methodically
 - Write structured incident reports
 - Explain detection logic in interviews
-

Month 4 (Days 91–120)

Detection & Log Analysis Mastery

Core Competencies:

- Log sources (Windows, Linux, firewall, web server)
- SIEM fundamentals
- Alert triage methodology
- False positive vs true positive analysis
- MITRE ATT&CK mapping

Real Platforms to Use:

- LetsDefend – Realistic SOC simulations
- Blue Team Labs Online – Investigation scenarios
- Splunk – Practice log searching
- Wazuh – Understand detection rules

Execution Plan:

- Investigate 3 simulated alerts per week.
- Write full investigation notes.
- Map alerts to MITRE techniques.

Deliverable:

Mini Incident Report Portfolio (3 documented cases).

Month 5 (Days 121–150)

SIEM & Detection Engineering Basics

Core Competencies:

- Writing basic detection queries
- Understanding log normalization

- Alert severity classification
- Creating use cases

Platforms:

- Elastic (Elastic SIEM labs)
- Security Onion – SOC lab environment
- TryHackMe – SOC Level 1 path

Execution Plan:

- Create 5 detection use cases.
- Write sample alert response playbooks.
- Build a home lab with log ingestion.

Deliverable:

SOC Investigation Project 1 (Full attack simulation).

Month 6 (Days 151–180)

Advanced Investigation & Interview Readiness

Focus:

- Lateral movement detection
- Brute force detection
- Web attack investigation
- Reporting maturity

Deliverable:

Advanced Case Study:

“Investigating a Simulated Credential Compromise”

Outcome:

You can walk an interviewer through an alert lifecycle confidently.

2 DFIR TRACK (Digital Forensics & Incident Response)

Outcome After 90 Days:

You can:

- Acquire and analyze forensic artifacts
- Reconstruct attack timelines
- Write professional forensic reports

Month 4

Artifact & Log Deep Analysis

Core Competencies:

- Windows Event Log analysis
- File system artifacts
- Timeline creation

Platforms:

- Autopsy
- SANS Institute (Free DFIR resources/blogs)
- CyberDefenders – DFIR labs

Execution:

- Analyze 2 forensic images.
- Extract artifacts.
- Document findings.

Month 5

Memory & Disk Investigation Platforms: •

Volatility Foundation

- Magnet Forensics (free resources/webinars)

Focus:

- Memory dump analysis
- Persistence detection
- Timeline reconstruction

Deliverable:

Forensic Case Study 1.

Month 6

Full Incident Reconstruction

Simulate:

- Phishing → malware execution → persistence

Deliverable:

Comprehensive Incident Response Report (15–20 pages structured).

Outcome:

You speak like an investigator, not a lab student.



3 THREAT INTELLIGENCE TRACK

Outcome After 90 Days:

You can:

- Profile threat actors
- Map campaigns to MITRE
- Write intelligence briefs

Month 4

Intelligence Foundations

Platforms:

- MITRE ATT&CK framework
- Mandiant threat reports
- Recorded Future blog

Focus:

- Understanding TTPs
- Intelligence cycle
- Reporting structure

Deliverable:

Threat Actor Profile 1.

Month 5

Campaign Analysis

Platforms:

- VirusTotal
- AlienVault OTX
- MalwareBazaar

Deliverable:
Campaign Breakdown Report.

Month 6

Strategic Intelligence Writing

Write:

Executive-level intelligence brief.

Outcome:

You can speak to both technical and business stakeholders.

CLOUD SECURITY TRACK

Outcome:

Understand cloud architecture & secure it.

Month 4

Cloud Foundations

Choose one:

- Amazon Web Services
- Microsoft Azure
- Google Cloud

Learn:

- IAM
- VPC
- Storage security

Platform:

Use free tier accounts.



Month 5

Cloud Misconfiguration & Monitoring Platforms:

- CloudGoat
- Prowler

Simulate:

Misconfigured S3 bucket exposure.

Month 6

Cloud Security Case Study Build:

“Securing a Multi-Tier Cloud Architecture” project.

Outcome:

You can speak cloud security fluently.

GRC TRACK

Outcome:

Risk-aware, compliance-literate professional.

Month 4

Framework Literacy

Study:

- ISO 27001
- National Institute of Standards and Technology Cybersecurity Framework

Month 5

Risk Assessment Practice

Simulate risk register creation.

Month 6

Audit Simulation

Build:

Mock compliance audit report.

Outcome:

You can speak governance confidently.

HELP DESK / SYSTEM ADMIN TRANSITION TRACK

Outcome:

Infrastructure-aware security candidate.

Month 4

Active Directory & Troubleshooting

Platforms:

- Microsoft Learn
- Cisco Networking Academy



Month 5

Server & Patch Management

Set up:

Windows Server lab.

Month 6

Security Hardening Project

Deliverable:

“Hardened Enterprise Environment” case study.

Final Strategic Positioning

Each track ends with:

- 2–3 documented portfolio projects
- Interview-ready narratives
- Real platform experience
- Confidence built from structured repetition

This is not rushwork.

This is professional formation.

PART 2 : BUILDING A PORTFOLIO THAT COMMANDS RESPECT

A strong portfolio does not list tools.

It demonstrates thinking.

project must follow this structure:

The Investigation Template

1. **Background:** What happened?
2. **Objective:** What were you trying to determine?
3. **Environment Setup:** Lab details.
4. **Investigation Process:** Step-by-step actions.
5. **Evidence Collected:** Screenshots and log snippets.
6. **Analysis:** What patterns did you identify?
7. **Conclusion:** What happened?
8. **Mitigation Recommendations:** How to prevent it.

This format mirrors real-world reporting.

Recruiters notice this.

Portfolio Checklist

Before publishing a project, ask:

- Did I explain my reasoning?
- Did I show my methodology?
- Did I avoid copying someone else's walkthrough?
- Does this show independent thinking?

If yes, publish.

PART 2 : VISIBILITY AS A STRATEGY, NOT EGO

Visibility is not about showing off.

It is about signaling competence.

Each week, post one of:

- A lesson learned from a lab
- A mistake you corrected
- A breakdown of an attack technique
- A mini case study

When you document publicly:

- You reinforce your understanding.
- You attract mentors.
- You attract recruiters.
- You differentiate from silent learners.

Visibility Planning Worksheet

Every Sunday, plan:

1. What did I learn this week?
2. What problem did I solve?
3. What insight would help another beginner?
4. What project milestone did I reach?

Turn one into a public post.

Consistency over perfection.



PART 2 : THE JOB APPLICATION EXECUTION STRATEGY

Most beginners apply emotionally.

Instead, apply strategically.

For each job description:

1. Highlight required skills.
2. Match them with your portfolio evidence.
3. Rewrite your CV bullet points to reflect measurable investigation actions.
4. Prepare to speak confidently about your documented projects.

If you cannot speak deeply about your own project, you are not ready.

Interview Preparation Template

For each project, prepare answers to:

- Why did you approach it this way?
- What was the hardest part?
- What would you improve?
- What real-world scenario does this simulate?

Confidence comes from preparation.

THE 9-MONTH EMPLOYABILITY MAP

Month 1–4: Foundations

Month 5–7: Specialized labs + 2 major portfolio projects

Month 8: Advanced project + visibility consistency

Month 9: Applications + networking + mock interviews

If executed properly, you are no longer “trying to break in.”



You are presenting yourself as a structured, skilled entry-level professional.

FINAL TRUTH

Cybersecurity does not reward noise.

It rewards clarity, depth, and proof.

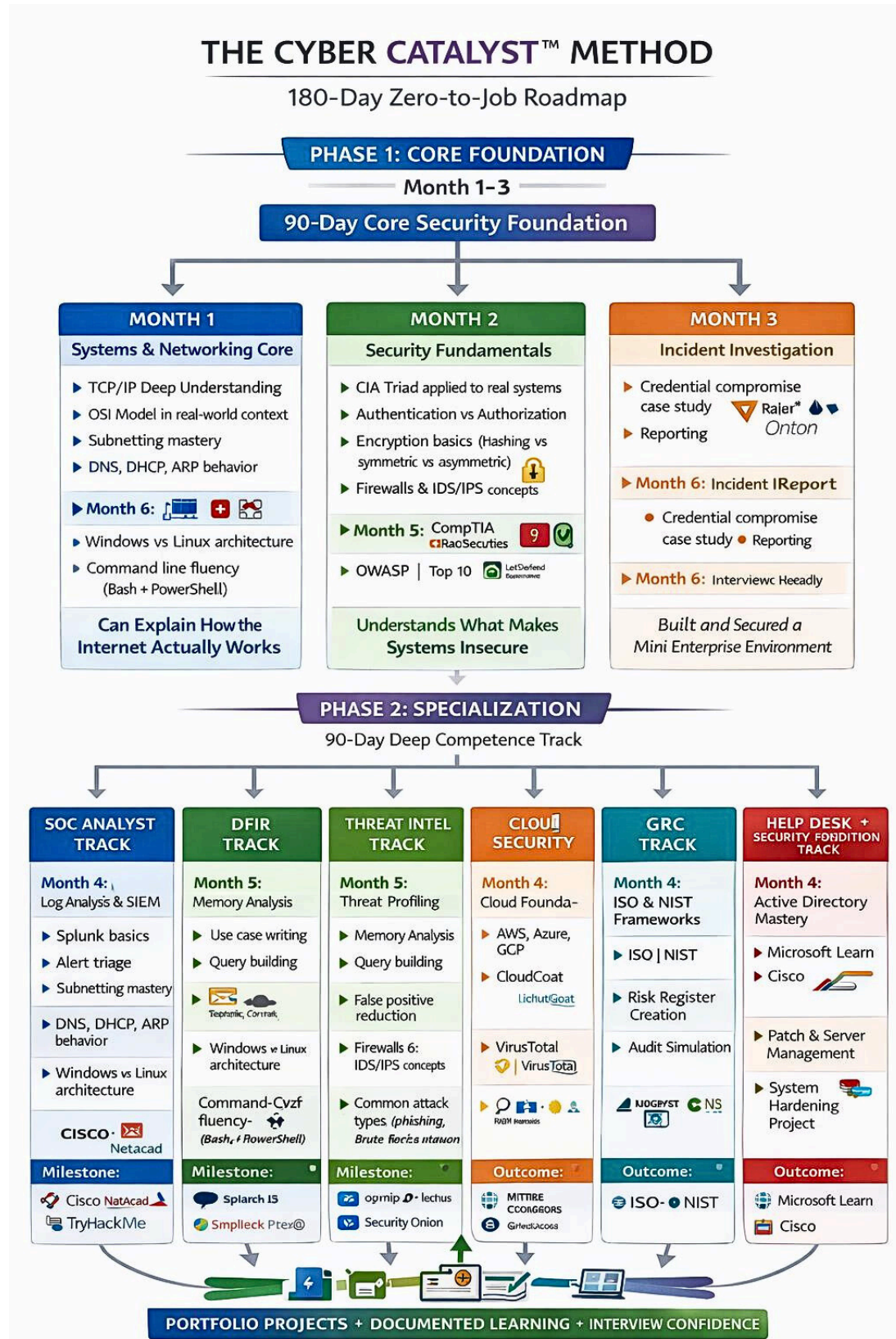
If you follow this system with discipline, you do not need ten certificates.

You need focused skill, documented thinking, and strategic positioning.

That is how a beginner becomes employable.



Figure 1: Here is an info graphics to summarize everything I have said.



About Victoria Simon

TheCyberCatalyst

I am VictoriaSimon,also known as The Cyber Catalyst. I help beginners gain clarity in cybersecuritysotheycangofrom zero knowledge to job ready with confidence.

Through mymethod,Iguidelearners to:

- Buildstrongtechnicalfoundations in networking, Linux, Windows, and cloud
- Choosetherightspecialization for their strengths
- Createaportfoliothatproves skill
- Applyforjobswithconfidence

I am passionateaboutmakingcybersecurity clear and actionable. My goal is to help you stop feeling lost,startbuildingrealskills, and secure your first role.

Connect With Me

Follow me for tips, tutorials, and guidance:

- **LinkedIn:** [linkedin.com/in/victoriasimon](https://www.linkedin.com/in/victoriasimon)
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Cybersecurity
Service

**VICTORIA
SIMON**

Digital forensics | Threat Intelligence | SOC Analyst

GitHub @cybervixy

